the Raksha Mantri, Shri Kundan Kumar, who in turn put me through to the Honourable RM, Shri Rajnath Singh. The RM was at the airport and to depart shortly for the US. However, he very graciously took my call and conveyed his congratulations and best wishes.

By the time I returned to the dining area, the news had already been received by everyone present. It was breaking news on every mobile. Apparently, I was the only one not carrying a mobile that day! General Rawat was the first to congratulate me, followed by the other two Chiefs, Admiral Karambir (KB as he was affectionately called), my childhood friend, and Air Chief Marshal RKS Bhadauria (RK), my squadron type from Lima Squadron. KB's mother, Raji Aunty, whom I had known since our Devlali days, and who was staying with KB at the time, also came out to congratulate me. She gave me a warm hug and said, 'I wish Sudha (my mother) had been here to see this day.' I hugged her back, and it was as if I was hugging my own mother.

We returned home to a deluge of calls. Isha and Amala, too, had been receiving congratulatory messages but in the absence of any confirmation from us, did not know how to respond. In fact, I had spoken to Isha just before leaving for dinner and had not said anything, so she was the most puzzled. News does indeed travel fast. My ADC, Capt Taran, had, in the meanwhile, arranged for an impromptu celebration. The Officers on my personal staff—Vikrant, Rakesh, Aneel, along with their wives, Madhavi, Naina and Shruti—all came trooping in to wish us. We popped another bottle of champagne, the third of the evening, and we all breathed a sigh of relief.

Veena fondly remembers that night. Our parents were asleep so we did not wake them up. She called her sister Uma and Isha; they had already received calls from well-wishers but

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